

MANDAR DEODHAR

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **Majlis, through its all-women team of lawyers, provides socio-legal help to domestic/ sexual abuse victims**
- **It also conducts training for police, public prosecutors, judiciary and social workers**
- **It has supported over 100,000 women and child victims and trained around 40,000 officials**

If

justice is a hard-won commodity, it is even more so for victims of domestic violence and sexual abuse, mostly children and women. On one hand exists an unfeeling justice system bristling with masculine barbs; on the other, a harsh, judging society. This is where Majlis, launched in 1991 by Flavia Agnes, has been making a difference—from providing socio-legal aid to domestic/ sexual abuse victims to policy-level interventions, and capacity-building for stakeholders like the police. A victim of domestic abuse herself, Agnes left home and got a law degree. As she started practising, she realised there weren't lawyers with a feminist understanding. Today, the association of women lawyers and activists has an all-women team. Their focus is on helping women, especially victims of violence, to litigate. "Women feel their lawyers can be compromised as husbands are richer. Here, they feel secure as the lawyer cannot be compromised," says Agnes, adding that lawyers worked pro bono or for nominal fees for victims. "Majlis is a unique organisation that works on the rights of women and children. We started at a time when the term 'domestic violence' was not uttered," says Audrey D'Mello, director. "Transforming victims into survivors is the role it plays."

Not just that, Majlis conducts role-specific training for investigating officers, the judiciary, lawyers, members of the child welfare committee and social workers.

"The whole idea is to demystify the laws," says D'Mello. Agnes says that they made courts women-friendly through their policy interventions, including removing the ceiling on maintenance given to deserted women, making divorce accessible for Christian women and conducting identification parades with sensitivity for the dignity of rape victims. "The tidal wave of violence against women and children is far from over. We need not just lawyers who litigate, but women and children aware of their rights," says Ingrid Srinath, a board member.

BENEFICIARYSPEAK

"I was thrown out by my husband, with nothing to fall back on. Majlis placed me in a shelter, provided legal aid, supported me in the lockdown. My case is at the mediation stage"

SALONI, *a cook, who was told about Majlis by a neighbour*

Majlis works with partners like the Akanksha Foundation, which runs schools in Mumbai, Pune and Nagpur with municipal corporations, and Creative Handicrafts, an NGO that provides skilling to underprivileged women. These groups refer women and children in distress to Majlis. How secure that safety net was became evident during COVID-19, when the Majlis team, at substantial risk, helped women abandoned by the system. ■